

Guardian 卫报

Gaming in their golden years: why millions of seniors are playing video games

退休后的游戏生活：为什么数百万老年人玩电子游戏



P1 Michelle Statham's preferred game is Call of Duty, a fast, frenetic military shooter inspired by real history. She typically spends six hours a day livestreaming to Twitch from her home in Washington state, chatting to her more than 110,000 followers. She boasts about how she'll beat opponents and trash-talks as she races across rooftops to avoid enemy fire. When she's hit, she "respawns" at a checkpoint and jumps right back into the fray.

P2 The military shooter game has a predominantly young male user base, but Statham's Twitch handle is TacticalGramma — a nod to the 60-year-old's two grandkids. Her lifelong gaming hobby has become an income stream, as well as a way to have fun, stay sharp and connect socially. "A lot of people are surprised that someone my age is playing video games," Statham admits. She finds the gameplay exhilarating, particularly landing long sniper shots or taking down enemies midair.

P3 Statham juggles in-game multitasking with live-chatting to her multigenerational audience. Younger followers have taught her slang, while she keeps gaming from displacing physical activity by exercising daily, often going to the gym with her daughter.

P4 Statham is one of the 57 million Americans over 50 who game, a group representing 28% of roughly 205 million total US gamers, according to recent data from the Entertainment Software Association. Nearly half of Americans in their 60s and 70s play some form of video game every week, as do more than a third of people in their 80s. As more gamers age, older adults are becoming increasingly visible in the gaming mainstream.

P5 "Age is like having a sign around your neck saying: 'I'm old and I can't do this,'" says Will, a 72-year-old retired navy veteran from Missouri who streams games to 1.4 million YouTube subscribers under the username GrndpaGaming. "That's not the case with me and other older gamers out there," he says. "Someone my age can keep up with technology."

P6 Some research suggests older adults may benefit from gaming, though the effects vary by game type. There are games designed to boost memory and attention, as well as puzzle games that require players to remember patterns, sequences and spatial layouts. Such games have been shown to help players of any age improve visual memory and cognitive processing. Fitness games that incorporate physical movement may also improve balance and coordination.

P7 Dr Gregory West, an associate professor of psychology at the University of Montreal, studied gamers of all ages in 2018. He found that participants who spent hours playing first-person shooters experienced a reduction in grey matter in the hippocampal region of the brain, while those who played games involving exploration of 3D open worlds showed improvement in the same area. Reduced hippocampal volume is associated with a higher risk of neuropsychiatric illness, West explains.

P8 However, West cautions against drawing simple conclusions. His study did not focus specifically on older adults, and he notes that seniors who succeed in competitive gaming likely start with strong cognitive abilities. Multiplayer games can also provide social benefits. "Older adults, through playing video games online with other people and communicating through microphones, are receiving real social stimulation," he says.

P9 "As long as you keep your brain active and functioning, you're not going to just deteriorate away," says Will. Even amid combat games, the social interactions can be surprisingly warm. "People always say: 'I love you, Gramps. Keep on doing what you're doing,'" he says.

P10 Gaming can also help people manage a variety of ailments, says Dr Kris Alexander, an associate professor of media production at Toronto Metropolitan University who helped launch GameRx. Studies suggest that playing Tetris shortly after a traumatic experience may reduce PTSD symptoms, while virtual reality environments can help lessen pain for burn victims. Alexander believes gaming has clear potential benefits for seniors, though physical challenges like joint pain and declining vision can pose barriers.

P11 As the senior gaming population grows, so may demand for accessibility tools. Will, who required surgery in 2010 that left him with limited mobility, now uses an adaptive gaming keypad that allows him to position keys comfortably. Other tools — including voice controls, foot pedals and custom controller modifications — are making gaming more accessible.

P12 Will hopes his visibility will inspire others. "If I can do it at my age with this handicap, you can, too," he says. After all, you're never too old to respawn.